

PHOTOSYNTHESIS



CREATED BY
DAVID QUANG PHAM

Photosynthesis The Movie

In a world of photogenic plants, a transplant must earn her green card or else she's uprooted and loses custody of her son, Parsley.

FOR MOM, GARDENER, PHOTOGRAPHER, TRANSPLANT

Photosynthesis is inspired by David's mother Hue (way), who immigrated from Vietnam with a camera and a dream to make the best garden possible with seeds she has never seen before.

David and his mother bonded over animated films like *Finding Nemo* or *A Bug's Life*. His dream is for him and his family to watch an animated film and series of their creation.



The Plant-based Musical Comedy

Set in the garden nation of Woodwork, *Photosynthesis* follows Rau Ram, a cilantro transplant striving for a better life for her son, Parsley. In this world, citizenship is literally visible: natural-born plants or transplants with green cards have green hands, while transplants like Rau have red hands that mark them as outsiders. After years of struggling to run a salon in the urban sprawl of Dirty City, Rau faces her greatest threat: the newly ratified Weed Out Act, which authorizes the uprooting of any undocumented plant. To secure her family's future, Rau must decide how much of her cultural roots she is willing to sacrifice to blend in, all while her son discovers a community of "Figs" and outsiders who believe true belonging isn't found in a color, but in a shared garden.



RAU RAM



RAU RAM is a resilient cilantro and owner of the Salontro salon in Dirty City. Fleeing conflict in Paddy Kingdom, Rau raises her natural-born son, Parsley, to be the “picture perfect” child to help earn her green card in a nation that views her as invasive. She maintains a shaky relationship with her neighbor, the nightclub owner Malus, but sometimes views Malus’s unruly nibbling, Pyrus, as a necessary friend for Parsley.

PARSLEY RAM



PARSLEY RAM is an optimistic herb and only friend of his overprotective mother, Rau. He helps at the salon and tutors at Rootimentary school. Unlike Rau, he admires the Fig community and connects with Pyrus, who challenges his sheltered worldview.

PYRUS CRABAPPLE



PYRUS CRABAPPLE is free-spirited pear with a flair for troublemaking, often retreating to their pet bee Bombus. After being suspended from Terra Hill Conservatory, their mother sends them to Malus's for the summer. They soon find an unexpected, fruitful friend in the little herb next door, Parsley, who helps them turn a new leaf.

MALUS CRABAPPLE



MALUS CRABAPPLE is the down-to-earth owner of the FigLeaf nightclub. A Paddy War veteran, they share a symbiotic but conflicted business relationship with Rau, who sees them as unnatural. Malus must confront their own tragic past of parental abandonment by ensuring their teenage nibbling Pyrus finds belonging.

SHELBY BOMBUS



SHELBY BOMBUS is Pyrus's loyal pet bee. An intellectual who solves puzzles and stings insults in honey ink, Bombus speaks only in unintelligible buzzes, mirroring the experience of many children of immigrants who cannot speak their mother tongue.

Secretary Rhizo Blomquist

The Secretary of Garden Security and head of the Soil and Plant Protection (SAPP) Agency. They are the root of suffering for many transplants. Canna's twin.

Mayor Canna Blomquist

The rotten and fourth wall-breaking mayor of Dirty City. Rhizo's twin.

President Pumpkin Eater

The President of Woodwork. They are the epitome of a cheater and votes in the Weed Out Act.



Woodwork

Capital: Rosenthal, B.C. (Battle Creek)

Largest City: Battle Creek

Official Language: Woodworkan (English)

Demonym: Woodworkan

Government Federal Presidential Republic

President: Pump King Eater

First President: George Rosenthal

Common Ethnicity: Oaks

Paddy Kingdom

Capital: Noiha

Largest City: Vuon

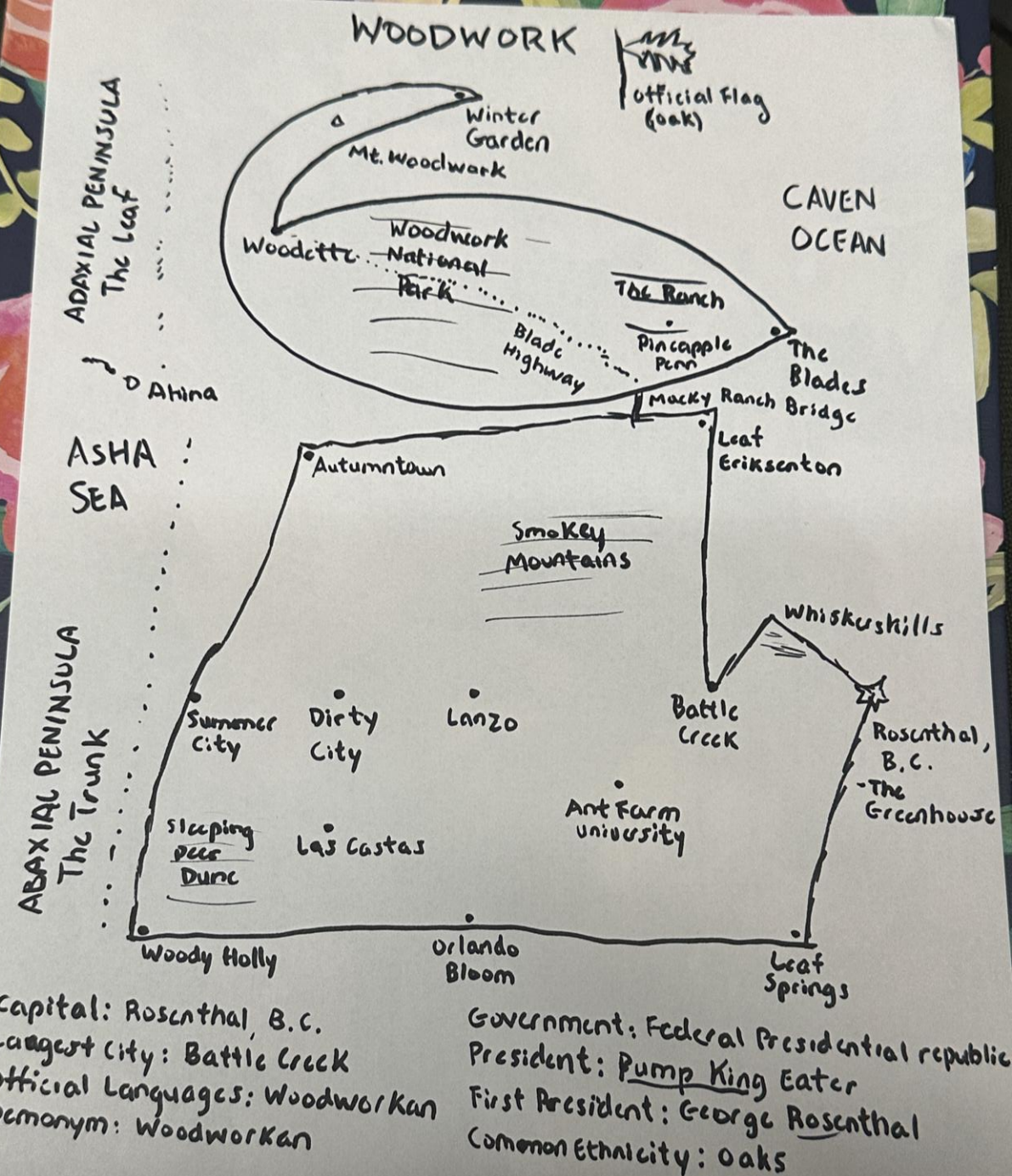
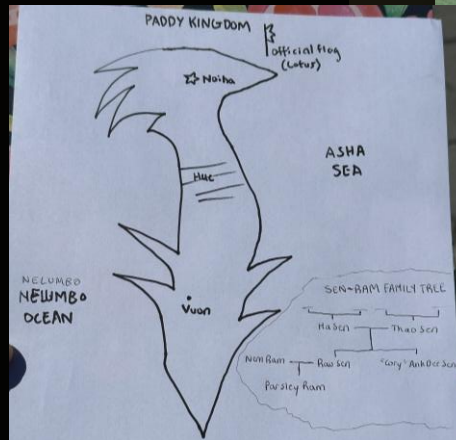
Official Language: Paddish

Demonym: Padi

Government: Unitary Parliament Const. Monarch

Monarch: Hoa Sen VII

Common Ethnicity: Lotuses & Herbs



PLOT SUMMARY

Act I (Root): Rau Ram arrives in Woodwork as a young, pregnant transplant fleeing her home, Paddy Kingdom. Eleven years later in Dirty City, she runs Salontro, a salon for plants. She raises Parsley to be picture-perfect to avoid the attention of Secretary of Garden Security Rhizo Blomquist. The status quo is shattered when Rhizo announces a crackdown on all "invasive species," leaving Rau no time to get her pending green card.

Act II (Growth): Rau enters an alliance with her flamboyant landlord, Malus Crabapple, who runs the neighboring FigLeaf nightclub. While Rau tries to buy her way into citizenship through bribes and performative actions, Parsley befriends Malus's nibling, Pyrus, a pear who

leads him on unruly adventures. Tensions peak when Rau, desperate to prove her loyalty to Woodwork, betrays her own community by handing over a list of undocumented transplants to Rhizo. As a reward, she finally receives her green card.

Act III (Turnover): The government targets FigLeaf for demolition, forcing Rau to choose between her status and friends. In an act of solidarity, she leads a protest that causes her to lose her citizenship. Despite the protest, the building is leveled, but Rau uses her life savings to fund FigLeaf's reconstruction. In the end, Rau finally finds belonging in the thriving garden her chosen family built together, not in a green card.

INTENTION (SCIENCE EDUCATION)

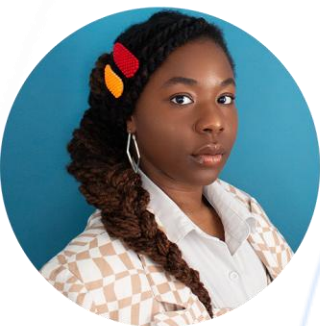
Plant science is here to tell human stories—from kids' self-esteem to the real-world anxieties of immigration. *Photosynthesis* is deeply personal to David; it's rooted in his own life as the son of immigrant parents and his academic background in plant science. *Photosynthesis* is ready to show that every garden and community need biodiversity to thrive. And we need music!

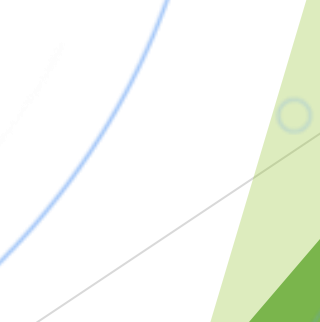




Directors Writers Producers Stage Managers Librarians Artists Musicians

Musicians





Parsley Ram

Ram Ram

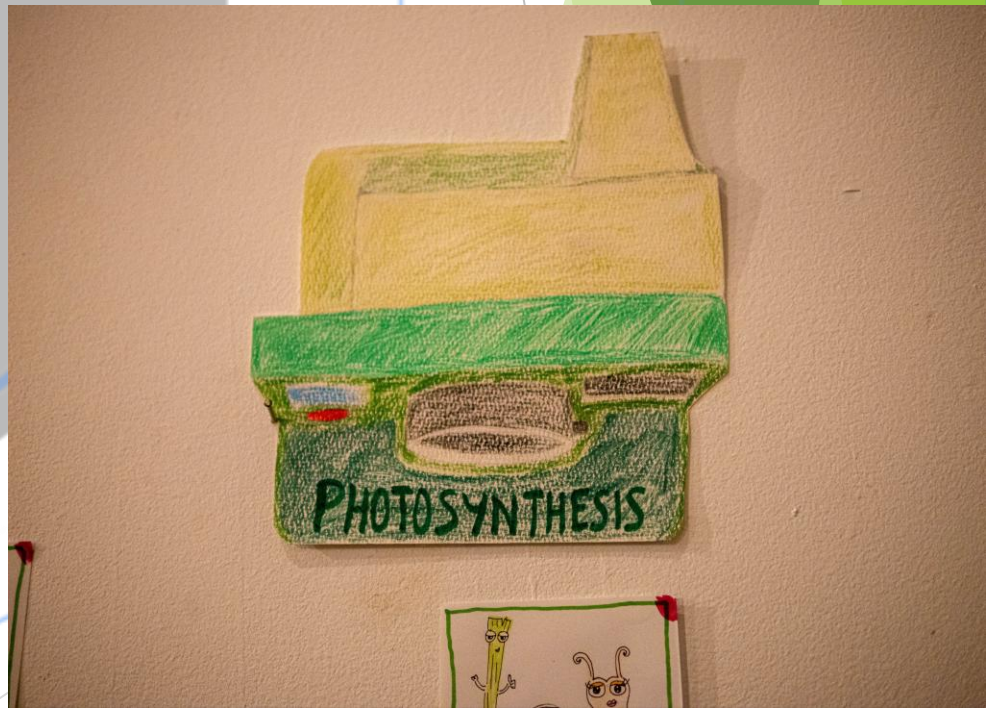
Ram Ram

Ram Ram

Ram Ram

Blomquist

DJ Cauliflower



PHOTOSYNTHESIS MUSIC SAMPLES

"Photosynthesis" (0:45)

The beloved theme song.

"Crop Top" (3:21)

Parsley's playful coming-of-age song with pentatonic sensibilities.

"Dirt on You" (3:51)

A goofy hip hop party song featuring DJ Cauliflower.

"A Natural" (6:10)

Rau's feature lullaby with pentatonic sensibilities.

"Turn Over a New Leaf" (7:17)

The communal song about being a better person for plants and transplants.

DavidQuang.com/Reel

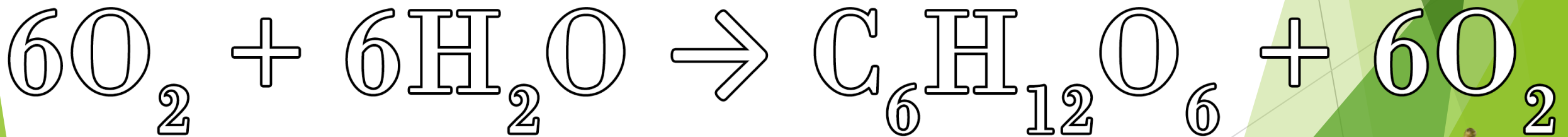


PHOTOSYNTHESIS EQUATION

Sugar Rush! (J = 144)

Chords: Bb Gm7 Eb F7 Eb Bb F Bb Gm7 Eb F7

Lyrics: C 6 H 12 O 6... plus 6 O 2... 6 car-bon 12 hy-dro-gen. 6 ox-y-gen... plus 6 ox-y-gen mol-e-cules. Pho-to-syn - the-sis. Pho-to-syn - the-sis. Pho-to!



o Pop o Punk o Cai Luong (Vietnamese Folk)

from the theme song: "Photosynthesis"



THE ANIMATED SERIES!



Follow the musical misadventures of Parsley and Pyrus as they navigate Woodwork and try to not get Salontro shut down.

SAMPLE COMPLETED EPISODES

FIRST PLANT

Cosmonaut Thaliana Rock-Cress and astronaut Dracaena Maize, the first two plants in space, visit Parsley's Rootimentary school, inspiring him to want to go to the Moon.

MINT CONDITION

Salontro is invited to Woody Holly to be Lami Mentha's makeup team for the reboot of her Mint Condition film series. While visiting the studios, Pyrus gets roped into a music opportunity of a lifetime.

PINEAPPLE PIZZA

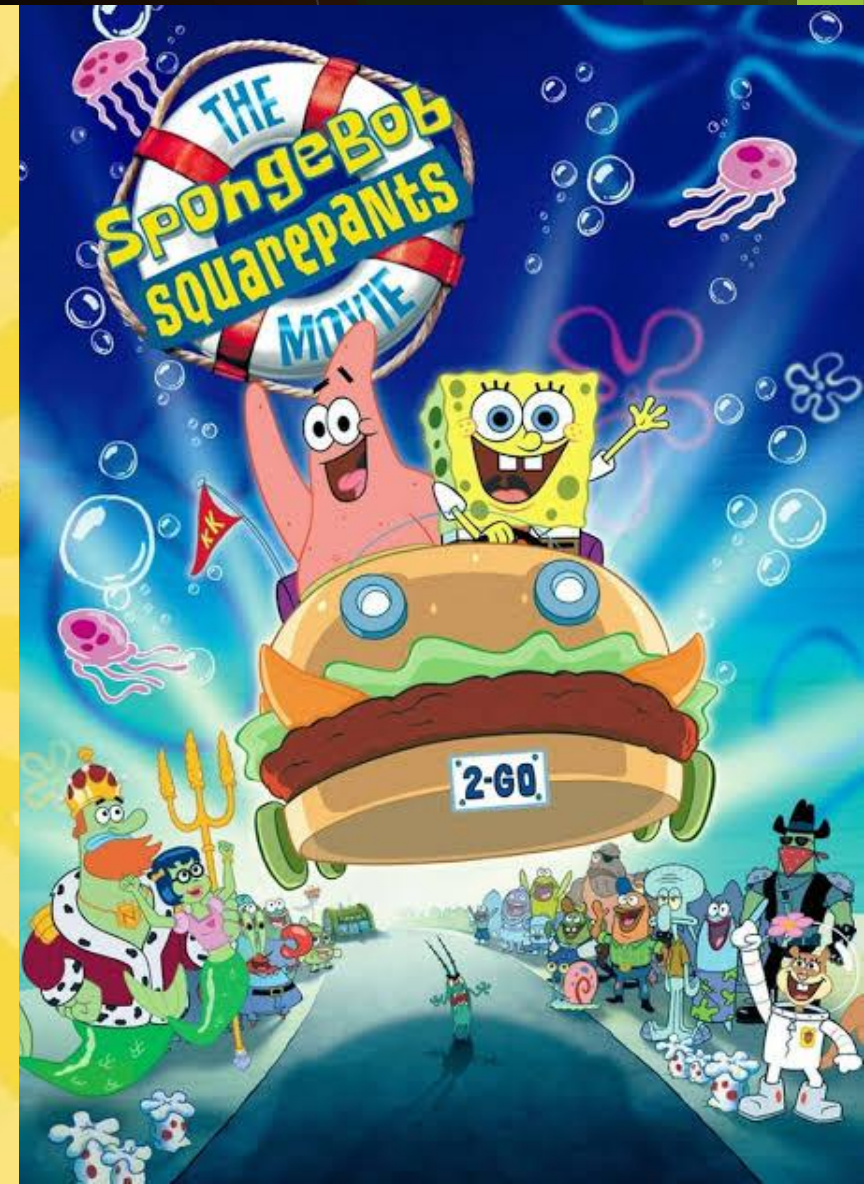
Parsley and Pyrus go camping. When a pineapple visits the park with their pizza truck, mysterious incidents occur. Should pineapples be allowed to make pizza, even if they lead to the apocalypse?

COMPS

Zootopia societal themes

Phineas and Ferb music

SpongeBob goofiness





2003 Space Camp,
Huntsville, Alabama



Michigan State Uni.
Astrophysics, 2014-18



Andrea M. Ghez,
Nobel Prize, Physics



David Built an
Astronaut Costume



VP of ΣΠΣ, physics
honor society



King Arthur, his knights
conquered England!

~AND SPEAKING OF SPONGEBOB,
MUCH LIKE CREATOR HILLENBURG~

DAVID QUANG PHAM

דוד קוואנג פאם

$9X - 7I > 3(3X - 7U)$, SCIENCE!



David managed
a greenhouse
at MSU,
2015-16

An award-winning songwriter, filmmaker, and science educator. His work engages the public in scientific and cultural literacy and are within fantasy, adventure, sci-fi, and queer genres. He created the series *Photosynthesis*; *Star Zoos*; *The Sugarcoats*; and *Solid, Liquid, and Gas*; and the stage musicals *Chemicals in the Water*, *Ellipses*, and *Turnover: A New Leaf*. His musicals have been staged regionally, Off-Broadway, and internationally. He is the 2026 Cinephilia fellow, Kellogg's Foundation film fellow, 2024 Great Performances fellow, 2022 Harriet Tubman Effect Institute composer, 2021 Playwrights Foundation fellow, and 2020 Working Title Playwrights apprentice. Pham received a BS with honors in astrophysics and theatre from Michigan State University. Be up to lightspeed at www.science.studio or @ScienceTheatre.

LET'S PLOT THIS GARDEN TOGETHER

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Check out *The Galaxy Family*,
a musical animated series in the works!

